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So, yeah, once again, thanks for joining me today. I'm going to talk a little bit about homesickness and using voice recordings to alleviate it, a couple of other variables. So, first of all, how are you today?

I'm doing well, yeah. It's a bit cloudy, but... Yeah. Wish it was sunny, but yeah, I'm doing well.

Yeah, same here, actually. Let me see. So, to kind of confirm, could you tell me where you're from?

I'm from the U.S. Originally, I was born there, and I think what's different from most of your participants is that actually I live in Germany.

Okay, yeah.

My connection to the Netherlands is through research and my boyfriend.

Ah, okay. Very interesting. Yeah, I was wondering through what medium you reached me. Yeah. Okay, so did you also grow up in the U.S.?

Yeah, I was born and raised there. So, I was in the U.S. until 22, and then I didn't like the U.S., so I moved to Germany to do my studies. And then, about a month ago, I became a German citizen.

Okay. Oh, yeah, actually. So, congratulations.

Thank you. That's nice.

So, what do you consider to be home?

Yeah, this is probably unusual, but for me, my home is Dortmund, Germany, actually. Yeah. I think because the situation in the U.S. is very bad, socially, politically, economically, and I don't have a huge family in the U.S. Also, because my parents themselves were immigrants from China to the U.S. Yeah. So, I don't have a... I mean, it's not a typical response, but people are moving a lot more these days, so maybe it might be interesting.

Yeah. No, I completely understand. And do you remember a moment where you were most homesick in your life, and if not a specific moment, then any moment where you were very homesick?

Yeah, I would say around, like, February, January, February, 2023, because I hadn't gone back home to U.S. in three years, actually. I left in October of 2019. Yeah. And there was lockdown and everything. I was quite nervous about getting COVID, and then I flew back to U.S. in March. Unfortunately, that actually kind of... In a good way, my experience in the U.S. is pretty poor because of personal reasons, but it killed my homesickness after that. Then it reversed. When I came back to Germany, I felt relieved to be back in Germany. Yeah. But yeah, with the whole situation in the U.S. and how people also have become over there. Yeah. So I missed being home for a bit, but I mean, I still miss, let's say, my parents. But yeah, it's a bit difficult. But yeah, right after, like, towards the tail, I'm just COVID.

Yeah. Yeah. So you would really say that you don't really miss the U.S. anymore, at least not in the current state that it is in, but more just so your parents and maybe other close ones to you?

Yeah, parents and friends. But to be fair, to be honest, I never really miss the U.S. as a country to be honest. No, exactly. The unusual... I think that's unusual. But with the family and that's friends, that's probably the biggest aspect.

Yeah. Yeah, exactly. Okay, so now I want to move on to one of my variables, which is personal versus generic voice recordings. So I'm studying the effect of both on homesickness. And with personal voice audio, I mean, like, any voice recording form that resonates with you personally. So it doesn't mean necessarily that it has to be from someone that's close to you. But it needs to invoke a personal connection. So it could be linguistic, historical, cultural, music, some books you like, whatever you can think of that feels more close to you. And generic would be just the opposite of that. So thinking about voice recordings that exist or might exist, what type of voice recordings could you think of that would feel more personal to you? And why would they?

I think... Actually, I'm thinking about the Spotify AI DJ voice. And it's... Quite frankly, it's a voice based off, I believe, a black American. So it's just, like, one of my people. Yeah. And that feels very comforting. And when I did sports, like, I grew up in a mostly white town. Yeah. So I... So... But I don't know. I guess when I was doing sports and I went into, like, the New York City and the people that I almost come from around, that's what it reminds me of. So it's a bit weird for me to attribute, like, a specific, like, ethnic group. But... Yeah. It's not just, like, by ethnicity, but it's, like, he has a very distinct American sound. Yeah. And at the same time, he sounds like someone who, you know, listens to me because that's what these people... That's what the people I remember were like.

Yeah. Yeah, exactly. And maybe a bit more difficult question or at least a bit more in general. But in contrast to that, what do you think would make a voice recording more generic for you?

So resonate less. I feel like if it has a sort of... Maybe if it's a bit of, like, a TED Talk or inspirational voice, like, it starts to sound a bit condescending. Like, you caught this or something. Or maybe a bit of a newscaster voice kind of that way. But, like... So just... I'm not sure. If I'm understanding that, maybe just a bit the formality of it or maybe that it's a bit forced.

Yeah. Yeah, exactly. I can understand. Yeah. Okay. So what I'm going to actually send you now is another link. And the link is to another questionnaire, another Qualtrics questionnaire. Just going to grab it.

Okay.

And I'm going to let you hear some voice recordings. And based on that, you can fit in the questionnaire. Let me see. I'll send it in the chat right now. So you can keep this open at all times during the interview. It will have 15 items in total. And at first, you're going to be using the first five items. So what you will see in the questionnaire right now is something like someone is speaking in a native language about this and that. And I'm going to let you hear a recording that corresponds with that. And you can just fill in if you think it's very generic up to the point of view, think it's very personal. So based on what you think. And after every recording, I let you hear. You can tell me if you want to hear it again or if it was unclear or if you can go and continue to the next one.

Okay. So I enter my email address.

Yeah. So for the first statement, it just corresponds with the first recording I'm going to let you hear. And then on to the next ones, etc. After five recordings, we're going to go back to the interview and then make that switch two more times during the interview.

Great. Okay.

So please, first of all, let me hear if you can actually hear the words. So I'm going to let you hear it now. So could you actually hear it?

Yeah, I hear French. Okay.

Yeah. Yeah.

[Voice recording audio: recording 1]

Okay. So, yeah. So that one is the weather item. Okay.

Yes, exactly. Okay. So are you ready for the next one?

Yeah.

[Voice recording audio: recording 2]

Okay.

[Voice recording audio: recording 3]

[Voice recording audio: recording 10]

[Voice recording audio: recording 17]

Okay. All right. I pressed the next button.

Yeah. So we are going to return to the interview now and then get back to this later.

Okay.

So based on what you just heard and what you filled in, do you think specific elements or specific contextual factors made it either more personal or more generic? And if so, which of these factors made it so?

I don't know. I'm not really sure if it's the language as much. Like, I think for the first one with the French person talking about the weather, it actually seemed like very animated and like fun. The only problem was I couldn't understand him because I don't know French. Yeah. But it seemed very nice. And then the second one, I don't know who this person was, but that sounds pretty horrifying. Yeah. So, and then with the American talk about the weather, that was pretty nice. And then the other ones, the following ones, I don't recognize. I'm not sure which person it was, the moon or whatever. Yeah. Yeah, that sounded quite generic.

Yeah. Yeah. And then, I'm going to go to the meaningfulness of voice recordings now. And with meaningfulness, I mean, if a voice recording in any way feels important to you, relevant to you. So whether it kind of actually means something to you, this can be emotionally, but it can also feel important to you without emotions, just reminding you of something valuable or significant. And such a voice recording could also be very personal, but not meaningful or vice versa. And actually, can you describe what makes voice recordings meaningful to you? If you would think of any voice recording that could exist?

It makes something meaningful. Yeah, definitely. Like, for instance, the, what's the Spotify voice? It's not meaningful. It's just some AI voice. Yeah. It's not a meaningful voice. Maybe I'm thinking about, like, some sort of meme or, like, voice clip of someone saying something. It's not a voice clip. I don't have a recording of this, but I remember when someone I didn't know too well, but said that we had improved a lot and some really nice things. And I thought that was really meaningful. Yeah. Something like, that's like, there's context, there's content, and it's, like, you know,

genuine. Yeah. And consistent with the person. Like, we knew who she was before. I remember she would still, like, you know, practice with me, even though I was a nobody. Like, she got literally nothing from practicing with me, but still did it. So, that I find meaningful. There's, like, it's something I know, or it's something that someone I have a connection to.

Yeah, exactly.

From a meme standpoint, they, maybe, if there was, like, some recording from somebody I didn't know, maybe it was, like, it's about a topic that resonates a lot with me. I just can't think of anything at the moment.

Yeah. Well, that's clear. So, based on this, could you describe how this connects to your understanding between the difference of a personal or generic voice recording? And I kind of already think there's a connection, maybe, because you said it's a lot of the tone of voice. So, like, in the French recording, for example, you already said that you don't really know what they're saying, but it sounds genuine and fun. So, is there more to this connection on meaningfulness and the personal and genericness, you think?

I don't think so. What's strange is a lot has changed. I'm changing constantly. People always change. Yeah. And when I came back to the U.S., every time, especially in 2023, with the subsequent times, it's always a bit of a reverse culture shock, because Americans start to sound more fake. Yeah. Like, they're nice, but I don't think they're fake, but it doesn't sound right anymore. And, sorry, my internet is cutting out a bit. Can you hear me?

Yeah, I can. Yeah.

Okay, perfect. Sorry, maybe, hopefully it's just pixelated the screen. I think things are starting to become, like, sorry, the two constructs were generic and meaningful.

Yeah, so the question was, would you describe how this would connect to your understanding of the difference between voice recordings you consider personal versus generic?

Personal versus generic. Yes, so the meaningfulness compared to the personal and generic. Yeah, I guess something sounds personal, it can sound personal, right? But meaningfulness, it starts to shift, right? Like, the American voice can sound personal, and to me now, German voice also starts to sound quite personal. Yeah. Because I've been living there longer. But in terms of meaningfulness, I notice more and more that I don't connect with Americans as much anymore. Yeah. I connect with maybe other internationals who, like, had a similar story as they came to some country in their early 20s for a degree. Yeah. Or, like, other things. And, yeah, I started noticing

this when I meet other Americans, and they're on a different path or they have a completely different attitude for me.

Yeah, okay, exactly. And could you maybe think of a situation in which the same voice recording would feel more meaningful in one situation and less meaningful in another? And so an example of different situations would be being alone or surrounded by people, being in home or public, or feeling homesick or not.

I think... I think... I think... I think if I needed to, like, talk to an AI voice about, like, my feelings, like, if this was, like, since they're a substitute for a psychologist, I think it would be nice to hear, like, an American voice or somebody who understood. Because when I went to a psychologist in Germany, I mean, she needed some time to understand what I was talking about to begin with. Because she can understand everything herself. And that's just normal. Yeah. So that would have been nice. But in the crowd, like, let's say if I moved to the Netherlands for, like, in the future, which is very plausible, I would like to maybe... I wouldn't mind hearing some Germans. Let's just leave it. That is strange. But as much as I make fun of them. You would still like to hear... Yeah. Yeah, I wouldn't want to hear more Americans. I heard enough of them once in the Netherlands.

Yeah. I understand. Yeah. Okay. So let me see. We're going to go back to the questionnaire now. I'm going to let you hear the same five recordings again. You're going to have the same five statements, but then you can rank them based on the meaningfulness that you think it is. So yeah. You can let me know when you're ready for the first recording again.

I don't hear anything.

Oh no, sorry, I haven't played yet.

Oh, sorry, I am ready. No problem.

Okay, I'm going to play it now.

[Voice recording audio: recording 1]

[Voice recording audio: recording 2]

[Voice recording audio: recording 3]

[Voice recording audio: recording 10]

[Voice recording audio: recording 17]

All right. Okay. I'm ready, so I'll press the next button.

Yes. So, based on these recordings again, so do you think there are specific elements or contextual factors that affected the meaningfulness? And if so, what were the factors and how did they influence it?

I guess, like, for instance, the weather, it was not like what I would expect or maybe wouldn't expect because it's not the weather where I am right now. The moon, I mean, I do believe that the moon landing is real. So, I don't know. I guess it's just not a pertinent topic in my mind right now. Same thing with the Thanksgiving. I mean, that one's more because I did celebrate it with friends and family. So, there was more meaningfulness to it. It wasn't like... The context is not, like, embedded. It's not, like, super, super relevant to me, like, today, right now.

Yeah. Yeah. Okay. So, I will now move on to the last variable, which is the actual supportiveness for coping with homesickness. And with that, I basically mean whether you feel like a voice recording would alleviate your feelings of homesickness and to what extent, or the opposite. So, potentially worse in your homesickness and to what extent. So, please describe how you think voice recordings might impact your experiences of coping with homesickness. In what ways do you think it would impact it and why?

I think it would help a lot, actually. I'm not sure. In my case, it might be a recording of German. But, I think it would, it could help a lot in the future. If I would say I live in the Netherlands and I miss Germany. But, in that case, it would be because I worry about losing my grasp of the German language. But, also, like, the people I spend a long time with in, like, my home in Dortmund. And, spending a lot of time with people. So, I think, like, hearing, like, everyday life would be really nice. But, it wouldn't be the same as, like, being there. So, I think it could help a little bit. But, not, like, a crazy enough.

Yeah, because you say it wouldn't be the same as actually being there. So, do you think that, for example, you would move to the Netherlands. You would listen to some recording of, let's say, a friend talking in German. That's actually still there. Would you say that has an effect on homesickness coping?

Yeah, I think so. I'd actually, I would rather see something, like, a bit more, like, more neutral. Like, watch, like, news or, like, watch a documentary in German. Or, like, watch something in English, right? Yeah. That's the weird thing, because I was born in the U.S., so everything is still in English. So, it makes things a lot different. Yeah. Yeah, it's harder to miss the U.S. culture when it's still pervasive. But with Germans, it's a little different.

Yeah. Okay. And can you think of a situation or situations in which the same voice recording would feel more appropriate for coping with homesickness in one situation? And would be less supportive for coping in another situation?

Yeah. I think a really dark example would be, for instance, if a loved one passes away and you listen to a recording, it really depends on where you are at the moment. Yeah. Or, let's say, if your loved one hasn't passed away, it might be easier to see, watch a recording versus the other way around. Yeah. If they've passed away, then, you know, that's, like, it's the past. So, that's always a difficult thing.

Yeah. Yeah. Okay, so we're just going to go back to the questionnaire for the final time. I'm going to, once again, let you hear the same recordings and you can fill in the last five statements based on how supportive you would say they are for coping with homesickness. Okay. You ready?

Uh-huh.

Okay.

[Voice recording audio: recording 1]

[Voice recording audio: recording 2]

[Voice recording audio: recording 3]

[Voice recording audio: recording 10]

[Voice recording audio: recording 17]

Alright. So you can now submit the questionnaire because it's finished.

Okay.

Alright. So for these recordings for the final time, do you think there are specific elements of the situations that affected the supportiveness for coping with homesickness for you?

Yeah, I think actually, in the end, it's more about how the person sounds. Yeah. So with the first one, the French guy, it would have been more supportive if I could understand him. But otherwise, he sounds pretty nice to hear. Yeah. And like, I feel like there's like life out there and I don't feel so lonely and I can continue moving forward. Because I think ultimately, in my mind, I know the past is the past. I can't go back. Yeah. And I'm not really... I'm looking for like new things, but that still sound like nice and pleasant. Yeah. So again, like the tone of voice and just the way they speak is pretty influential. Yeah. So the woman, the American woman with the leather person, she also sound really nice. Yeah. Even though I can understand that, it's just... I don't even remember what she said, to be honest. Because it just, I knew it wasn't relevant. Yeah.

So even though the topic isn't really relevant or is pretty generic, then it can still feel more supportive because that language that's being used in the way that she's speaking is pleasant?

Yeah. But I think I'm not the typical case. Yeah. It's just my nature to like move around, I guess. So I don't really know. But I'm curious how the results turn out. So... Yeah. I expect that people are different from me. I don't know. But I don't know.

I'm gonna move on to the final part. So I would like you to imagine a voice recording of someone very close to you. So someone that's close to your heart, maybe a loved one, family member, whoever you can think of. And they are speaking to you about something personal. And if you would have a recording of that. So how meaningful would you think it is and why?

I think it would be very meaningful, yeah. Yeah. Yeah. And yeah, especially because like, it's not easy, but like my dad's pretty old. So, he was quite old when I was born. So I'd like to have more recordings of him.

Okay. Yeah.

But I'm not sure if I could hear every day.

No, exactly. Because how supportive for coping with homesickness do you think the same recording would be?

I don't think it would actually... I think it's more like to remember things when it's just time to go, but... Yeah. I don't think it would help.

No, exactly. Yeah. So maybe the recording that you chose specifically now, if it were to exist, it would be good to reminisce on and to think about it. But it could be more painful?

Yeah, I think so. Yeah.

You okay?

Yeah, I'm fine.

Okay, I can take a break if you want.

No, I'm good.

Okay. So that was actually already kind of it. So is there anything that we haven't discussed about maybe voice recordings, homesickness? That you still think is very important to share?

I'm not sure. I think in the future, there'll be a lot of like AI based on... Or like, creations. Like, let's say, if you could create like a AI version based on how my dad

speaks, for instance, that would be pretty interesting. But I'm like, not sure if that's a good idea, you know? Exactly. It kind of reminds me of like, in Harry Potter, where you have like, what was that, that stone where you can like talk to people from the dead. And there was a big caution to not do it too much because you might, you know, lose your grasp on reality or like, maybe go like insane, so to speak. I know that's a bit of a crass way to say it. Yeah, but I think it, yeah. So it would maybe be helpful in the short term, but you could lose yourself in the long term. Yeah, I'm not sure. I haven't really dealt with death too much in my life. So, or in a close extent. So I'm not sure how to deal with it in the future.

Yeah, yeah, exactly.

And so... Yeah, it's easier to leave than move away. Yeah. Oh, wait, let me see. I think the internet right now. Yeah, now it's back. Yeah.

So if you could think of one, if not, that's okay. But if you could think of a voice recording that would be helpful for alleviating homesickness, what do you think that would be and why?

Probably something funny. Yeah. Because like, in my hopes, I think longings, sadness is not always a bad thing. Like, you need to do that and you have to move up your emotions, but like, something funny would be like, quite good. Like, and it could be like, maybe something more general, like a comedian.

Just something that would be like a positive emotion kind of taking the edge off. Instead of looking for those feelings?

Yeah. Yeah.

Or it doesn't have to be necessarily super funny. It could be like, I think, like, you know how people talk to dogs. So like, this is a good boy, like that kind of stuff. So like, hearing that, it's not like as specific to a very specific situation.

Yeah. All right. Okay. Thank you. So that was it. Do you have anything else to add?

No, I don't. I think this is nice research. So I wish you well and am excited. I found out by the Slack channel. So I was curious.

Yeah. All right. Okay. Yeah. Thank you so much for joining. Thank you.

Yeah, of course. All right. Good luck. Yeah.

Thanks.

I'll see you around in the Netherlands

Yeah, maybe. Bye bye.